

Dada

A reaction to the horrors of the First World War, Dada was an anarchic artistic and literary movement that began in 1916 in neutral Zurich, Switzerland, where many artists and poets lived. Described by its perpetrators as 'anti-art', Dada was influenced by ideas from several other avant-garde movements. It began when artists and writers met at the Cabaret Voltaire, a nightclub owned by writer Hugo Ball (1886–1927) in Zurich. The name Dada was chosen by the poet Tristan Tzara (1886–1930) when he was looking for an illogical word in a dictionary. Diverse and irreverent, Dadaists protested against the brutality of war and the bourgeois society they believed had allowed such atrocities to happen. There was no coherent style, but the art, poetry and performances produced were often satirical and nonsensical. Dada spread to various cities around the world. Its founders included Ball, Tzara and the artists Jean (Hans) Arp (1886–1966), Marcel Duchamp, Francis Picabia (1879–1953), Kurt Schwitters (1887–1948) and, in Germany, Hannah Höch (1889–1978) and Max Ernst.



Duchamp, *L.H.O.O.Q. (Mona Lisa with Moustache)*, 1930